Does the arrival of Amritpal—as a self-styled 'Bhindranwale 2.0'—inaugurate a new chapter of that troubling story? When INDIA TODAY met him in January, he was ensconced in the 8x8 weatherproof tent he'd set up at a ground adjacent to the Jallupur Khera gurdwara, sitting on an electrically heated floor, swathed in blankets, to ward off the northern chill. In the backdrop: a life-size portrait of Guru Gobind Singh...and a photo of Bhindranwale.

Currently on a *Khalsa vaheer* (march to spread Sikhism), Amritpal's antics have disinterred the buried ghosts of Khalistan. His speeches mix talk of a "silent genocide" of Sikhs with homilies on a return to piety to end all suffering, such as drug addiction. It's not spiritualism of a quietist vein. He's not above asking youth to take up arms in defence of the faith—and that has consequences. In November, one Sandeep Singh, alias Sunny, picked up his licensed .32-bore gun and shot down the self-styled radical Hindu leader Sudhir Suri in broad daylight in Amritsar. Sunny admitted to being influenced by Amritpal, though police could not establish any direct link. The Bhagwant Mann regime, in fact, issued a diktat in mid-November banning the public display of weapons. But Amritpal openly advocates brandishing arms.

If Amritpal has developed a cohort of radical Sikh youth, following his words keenly in Punjab's dust-caked plains and in online spaces, it is because of the churn that has beset panthic politics—where religious fervour often strays from orthodoxy to radicalism. The old vanguard of panthic politics—the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD)—is in steep decline, after over a century of panthic voices dominating Sikh religious as well as political discourse. None of the lesser Akali factions is strong enough to replace the Badal-controlled SAD. Party chief Sukhbir Badal's father Parkash Badal had rebuilt the Akali Dal in 1995, bringing the fragmented leadership together. After the SAD's famous Moga convention, Badal

THE PANTHIC FACES

INCUMBENTS



↘ GIANI HARPREET SINGH

Who is he: The chief of Sikh seminary Damdami Taksal, he is also the acting jathedar (custodian) of Akal Takht, the community's highest spiritual seat

Panthic push: Finding his influence waning, the jathedar is pushing for panthic unity on contentious issues, such as the release of Sikh militants



↘ HARJINDER SINGH DHAMI

Who is he: Heads Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee, which is tasked with managing Sikh religious institutions

Panthic push: Drawing flak for being ineffective in dealing with proliferation of deras and churches in Punjab and separate gurdwara bodies elsewhere, he got portraits of Sikh militants installed in the Central Sikh Museum



↘ SUKHBIR SINGH BADAL

Who is he: The chief of Shiromani Akali Dal, the original custodian of panthic politics for over a century

Panthic push: Accused of ignoring panthic issues, such as the 2015 sacrilege incidents that happened under the SAD regime's watch, he's trying hard to regain lost ground. Fielded a jailed terrorist's sister in the Sangrur bypoll

NEW CHALLENGERS



↘ BALJIT SINGH DADUWAL

Who is he: A Damdami Taksal product, he is the former chief of Haryana Sikh Gurdwara Management Committee

Panthic push: A fierce critic of the Badal family, he spearheaded protests against the 2015 sacrilege incidents. Also played a key role in turning public sentiment against Dera Sacha Sauda. Has been pushing for gurdwara reforms



↘ MANJIT SINGH BHOMA

Who is he: A former terrorist, he is the chief of the Delhi gurdwara management body's Dharam Prachar Committee in Amritsar

Panthic push: Opposed to the Badal family's control over SGPC, he has been organising protests on the sacrilege and religious conversion issues. He is also the original petitioner in the high court for release of Sikh terrorists or 'Bandi Singhs'

THE KEY DEMANDS

↘ **PROPER INVESTIGATION AND SPEEDY CONVICTION** in the sacrilege incidents and the subsequent Kotkapura/ Behbal Kalan police firing that killed two protesters in 2015

↘ **THE RELEASE OF SIKH MILITANTS**, or 'Bandi Singhs', who remain lodged in jails for decades now. Beant Singh assassin Balwant Singh Rajoana is among them